

Feeble JUSTICE

A nation seethes in outrage as a retired police official is let off with a light sentence for molesting a minor who committed suicide. Her childhood friend vows to fight on.

| By Arvind Chhabra |

Nineteen years have passed. She's married, has two children, whom she's feeding quietly as the media throngs her Sector 6 home in Panchkula, a satellite township outside Chandigarh. Neighbours and friends crowd the large living room as the children stare goggle-eyed but 32-year-old Aradhana Gupta still blanches when she recalls the moment in 1990 when her friend, Ruchika Girhotra, then a bright-eyed 14-year-old with a dream to make it big in tennis, was molested by Shambhu Pratap Singh Rathore, then inspector general of police (IGP), Haryana. As if in slow motion, the scene unfolds before her eyes, Rathore pulling Ruchika towards him and Ruchika struggling to free herself. "When she was released from his grip, she ran out like someone possessed. She dusted her clothes wherever he had touched her. Later, whenever we talked about it, she would break down. I could see her spirit was being shattered," says Aradhana, who was then only 13 but would counsel her friend daily, telling her not to worry. She would get justice one day.

Unfortunately, despite Aradhana's battle, braving harassment and threats, it hasn't happened. On December 23, after 400 adjournments in special CBI courts and over 40 adjournments in the high court and Supreme Court, Rathore was given six months imprisonment and a fine of Rs 1,000. As he left the Chandigarh District Court with his lawyer wife, Abha, he even smiled, as if to mock the system he had once vowed to uphold. He even seemed optimistic that he would emerge victorious in reducing the punishment. "I am filing an appeal against this order. Truth will prevail and I will win," he said with complete lack of irony. For Aradhana, who had pursued the case since it was first filed by her mother Madhu Parkash, 60, in November 1997, in the Punjab and Haryana High Court, it was a rude shock. One that was shared in an unprecedented outpouring of outrage against the judgement, with MPs in Parliament saying the punishment handed out to Rathore



RATHORE AFTER THE SENTENCE

A LIFE TOO SHORT

August 12, 1990 SPS Rathore, a 1966-batch IPS officer and then IG, molests Ruchika Girhotra at the office of the Haryana Lawn Tennis Association.

September 3, 1990 Inquiry report by R.R. Singh, then DGP, indicts Rathore.

September 20, 1990 Ruchika is expelled from Sacred Heart Convent School for 'indiscipline'.

October 23, 1993 Her brother Ashu is arrested in 11 car theft cases.

December 28, 1993 Ruchika commits suicide.

November 1994 Rathore is promoted as the Additional

Director-General of Police, Haryana.

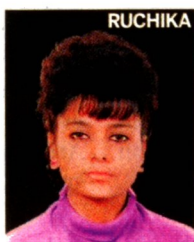
November 1997 Ruchika's friend's mother Madhu Parkash moves the high court seeking a CBI probe.

August 21, 1998 High court directs the CBI to conduct an inquiry.

November 16, 2000 CBI files chargesheet holding Rathore guilty of molestation under Section 354 of the IPC.

July 2002 Rathore retires as DGP, Haryana.

December 21, 2009 CBI court gives six months of rigorous imprisonment and a fine of Rs 1,000 to Rathore. He gets bail the same day. Two years is the maximum punishment under the provisions.



RUCHIKA